Episode 3

The Drowned Village

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Game Design and Narrative Specification

Setting	Floating village and abandoned stilt clinic, Tonle Sap Lake
In-story time	Monsoon storm · 1:30 AM – 5:00 AM
Playtime	3 – 4 hours
Seal	#3 · The Terracotta Water Jar
Version	2.0 · October 2026 · Draft for review

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01 Episode Overview

The 1925 photograph leads Sora to the Tonle Sap in the middle of a monsoon. She rows to an abandoned French-Khmer clinic on stilts, half swallowed by floodwater and haunted by the spirit of a woman who drowned there. In this place the water itself is the enemy.

LOCATION	WEATHER	PLAYTIME
Tonle Sap Lake Floating village and stilt clinic	**Monsoon storm** Rising floodwater	**3 – 4 hours** 3 acts
CORE MECHANIC	**ENTITIES**	**SEAL**
Water and warmth Rowboat, wetness, safe lights	**Chhlong Tonle · Neak Ta** Water spirit · storm surge	**#3 Terracotta Water Jar** Purified in a counter-ritual

1.1 Episode goal

Reach Uncle Sok's hidden vault in the flooded clinic, restore power to the drainage pump, recover the **Terracotta Water Jar** (Seal #3) from the iron safe and purify it before the clinic collapses into the lake.

1.2 Role in the series

Introduces	Rowboat navigation, wetness and body temperature, safe-zone lights, sealing windows and leaks, an enemy that moves only through water, and the fuse and generator puzzle.
Reveals	Uncle Sok used the abandoned clinic as a hidden sanctuary in the 1920s and stored a relic in its safe.
Leads to	A burnt piece of rubber stamped with a 1928 colonial company seal, pointing to Kampong Cham and Episode 4.

1.3 Visual identity

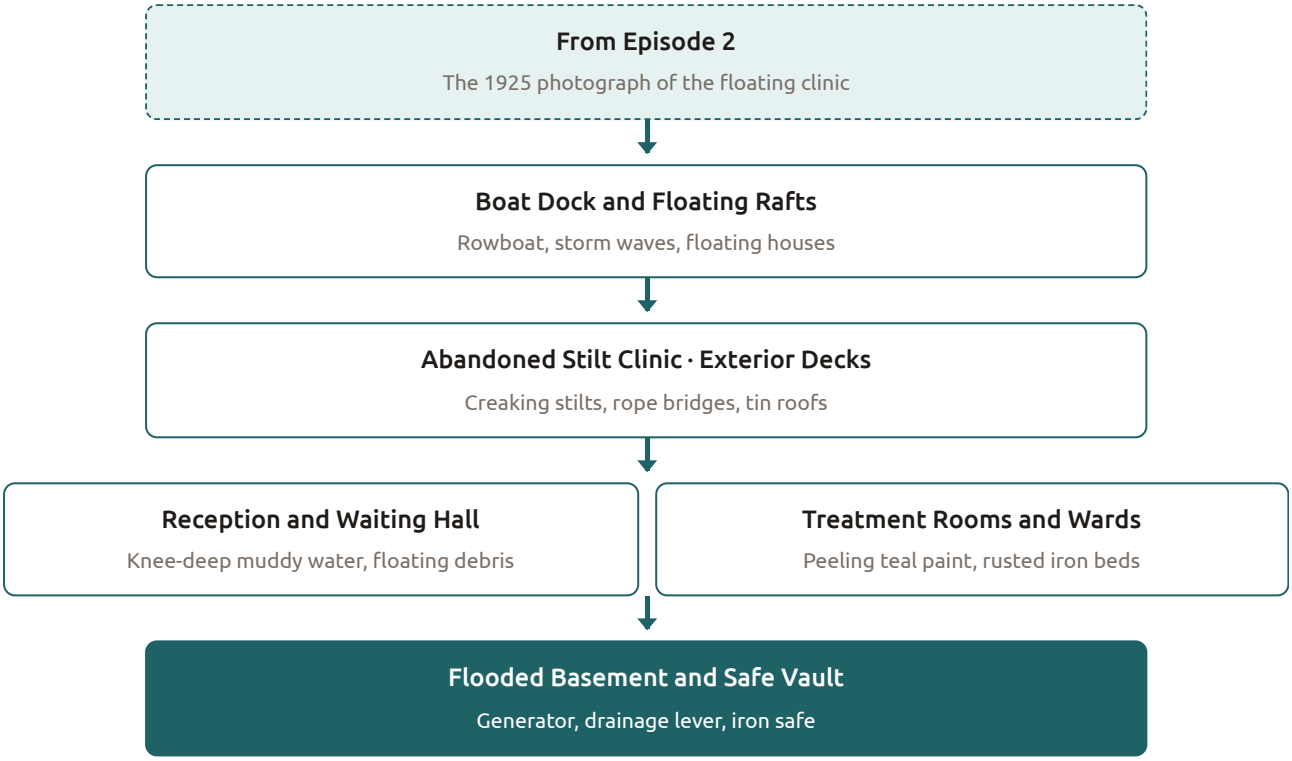
Cold dark teal, murky brown floodwater, glistening wet wood, rain streaking the view, lightning-flash shadows and warm amber lamplight reflected on black water.

02 Characters

Character	Role	Description	Gameplay function
Sora ស្រ៉ា	Protagonist	Soaked and pushed to her physical limits. She moves through the flooded structures by small boat and plank walkway, using her eye for architectural layout.	Player character.
Grandfather Pa Lok 70	Guide	A retired, reclusive fisherman living on an isolated floating raft. He recognises Uncle Sok in the photograph and tells the tragic story of the flooded clinic and its spirit.	Rents the rowboat; delivers the episode's rules.
Chhlong Tonle water spirit	Enemy	The tragic spirit of a young woman who drowned in the clinic during childbirth. She glides beneath the murky water and rises through flooded openings and dripping gaps in the ceiling, trailing long hair.	Hunts anyone who stands in water.
The Neak Ta shadow អ្នកតា	Antagonist	Growing more aggressive as the seals break. It drives the storm surge to trap Sora in the flooding lower rooms.	Raises the water; collapses the clinic.

03 Locations and Layout

3.1 Progression map



3.2 Area details

Area	Description and key props	Lighting	Gameplay use
Boat Dock and Floating Rafts	A cluster of rickety floating wooden houses tied to bamboo poles rising out of the black lake. Small wooden rowboats (ສຳປັ໊ນ), bamboo oars, woven fish traps, kerosene barrels, storm lanterns bobbing on the water.	Storm lanterns, lightning	Meeting Pa Lok; rowboat tutorial
Clinic Exterior and Decks	A two-storey French-Khmer medical clinic on thick wooden stilts over the lake. Faded teal walls; corrugated iron roofs drumming in the rain. Slick plank bridges, rope handrails, canvas tarps, rusted medical supply crates.	Lightning; fixed wall lamps	Entry; dry routes; fuse search
Reception and Wards	The ground floor is partly under knee-deep, murky water. Floating patient files, glass medicine vials, rusted iron bed frames, rocking chairs floating upside down, rainwater pouring through cracks in the ceiling.	Very dark; lamplight reflected on water	Aquatic stealth; window sealing

Area	Description and key props	Lighting	Gameplay use
Basement and Safe Vault	A low concrete and timber cellar under the clinic's main stilts, flooded to chest height during the monsoon. Contains an old diesel generator and an iron medical safe.	Generator indicator lights	Generator; safe; timed escape

04 Story and Gameplay by Act

Act I · The Monsoon Surge

Playtime 0:00 – 1:00 · Story 1:30 – 2:15 AM

NARRATIVE

Following the photograph, Sora travels by horse cart to the edge of the Tonle Sap (ទន្លេសាប), arriving at **1:30 AM** in a fierce monsoon. The lake heaves with surging waves.

She hires a small rowboat from Grandfather Pa Lok, an old fisherman. He warns her that the stilt clinic has stood abandoned since a tragic medical accident in 1920, and that no fisherman goes near it after midnight:

> *"The water remembers everything, girl. The spirit in that clinic drags down anyone who steps into her dark water. Keep yourself dry, and keep your light bright."*
>
> Grandfather Pa Lok

Sora rows through the storm toward the dark shape of the clinic, creaking high above the water.

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Rowboat navigation	The player rows a small wooden boat between floating structures, with water physics affected by waves and wind.
Wetness and warmth	Wading through floodwater slows Sora down and soaks her clothes. If she stays wet too long, her body temperature drops and her lamp flickers dangerously.
Drying lamps	Large fixed lamps on the clinic walls dry Sora and create temporary safe zones that repel the water spirit.

Act II · Whispers Under the Floorboards

Playtime 1:00 – 2:30 · Story 2:15 – 3:45 AM

NARRATIVE

On the clinic's lower deck, Sora searches for Uncle Sok's old storage vault. Water-damaged ledgers reveal that Sok used the abandoned clinic as a hidden sanctuary in the 1920s and locked a rare relic in the iron safe below.

In the flooded wards, the temperature plummets. The water around her ankles ripples when nothing moves it. The **Chhlong Tonle** appears, rising silently from openings in the flooded floor, a long-haired shape made of water.

To reach the vault, Sora must find three dry brass fuses on the creaking upper floors and restore power to the generator that runs the drainage pump.

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Aquatic stealth	The spirit travels only through water and flooded floors. Players watch for ripples and climb onto dry furniture, crates or upper walkways to avoid her.
Sealing windows and leaks	Sora uses wooden planks and canvas tarps to seal broken windows and roof leaks, stopping rain from flooding key puzzle rooms.
Generator fuses	Three dry fuses are stored in sealed medical tins. The player finds them while tracking the spirit by the slosh of wet, dragging footsteps.

Act III · The Sunken Safe and Seal #3

Playtime 2:30 – 3:30 · Story 3:45 – 5:00 AM

NARRATIVE

Sora installs the fuses and cranks the diesel generator to life. The machine shakes the floorboards as the drainage pump starts, and the water in the basement vault begins to drop.

She descends into the muddy basement. The iron safe stands in the centre. Using dates from Uncle Sok's medical logs, she sets the combination. Inside lies the **Ancient Terracotta Water Jar** (Seal #3), inscribed with protective Pali runes and filled with sanctified river soil.

As she lifts the jar, the Neak Ta strikes outside, smashing the clinic's support stilts. The building tilts toward the churning lake and the floodwater rushes back in.

GAMEPLAY

Element	Description
Timed vault escape	Climb out of the tilting, flooding basement, balancing on shifting floorboards and dodging falling debris.
Purification ritual	On the upper deck, Sora pours sanctified water over the jar while lighting three yellow candles arranged in a triangle around it.
Climax	As the counter-mantra is recited, a blinding flash bursts from the jar. The Chhlong Tonle dissolves into harmless mist and the waves around the clinic fall calm.

Resolution and Cliffhanger

Story 5:00 AM

Sora sits exhausted in her rowboat as the storm eases at **5:00 AM**, and the pale pink of dawn spreads over the lake.

She breaks the jar's clay seal. Inside, wrapped in oilcloth, is a burnt piece of dried rubber latex stamped with a French colonial seal from 1928: *Compagnie des Caoutchoucs de Kampong Cham*. A drop of blood seeps from the stamp onto her sketchbook map, pointing east to **Episode 4: The Rubber Plantation**.

05 Mechanics Reference

New mechanics in this episode. Values marked *target* are starting points for playtesting.

Mechanic	Rules	Feedback to the player
Rowboat	Left and right oar strokes steer and drive the boat. Waves and wind push it off course. Docking points let Sora step onto rafts and decks.	Oar sounds, boat rocking, spray.
Wetness	Rises while Sora is in water or rain, faster in deeper water. At high wetness she moves more slowly and loses warmth.	Wet screen-edge effect; dripping sounds.
Body temperature	Drops while wet. When low, Sora shivers (more noise) and the lamp flame flickers. At the lowest level she collapses and restarts from the last checkpoint.	Shivering breath; unsteady view; flickering lamp.
Drying lamps / safe zones	Standing in a fixed lamp's light dries Sora and warms her. The water spirit will not enter a lit safe zone. Some lamps need fuel or repair first.	Warm glow; steam from clothing.
Water level	Rooms flood over time unless their windows and leaks are sealed. The drainage pump lowers the basement level.	Visible water line; running water sounds.

06 Puzzle Walkthroughs

6.1 Sealing the rooms

Step	Action	Result
1	Find planks and canvas tarps around the decks and wards.	Materials in the satchel.
2	Board up broken windows and cover roof leaks in the key rooms.	Water stops rising in those rooms; dry routes open.

6.2 The generator

Step	Action	Result
1	Read the ledgers to learn the vault needs power for the drainage pump.	Objective in the sketchbook.
2	Find three dry brass fuses in sealed medical tins on the upper floors.	Three fuses collected.
3	Install the fuses and crank the diesel generator.	Pump starts; basement water drops.

6.3 The iron safe and the purification

Step	Action	Result
1	Find the significant dates in Uncle Sok's medical logs.	Combination noted in the sketchbook.
2	Enter the combination on the safe's dial.	Terracotta Water Jar (Seal #3); the collapse begins.
3	Escape the tilting basement to the upper deck.	Checkpoint.
4	Pour sanctified water over the jar and light three yellow candles in a triangle.	The seal is purified and the spirit is released.

07 Entities

Entity	Senses	Behaviour	How to survive
Chhlong Tonle	Senses anyone standing in water	Moves only through water and flooded floors. Rises from openings to seize Sora if she stays in the water near her.	Watch for ripples; stay on dry furniture, crates and walkways; use lit safe zones.
Neak Ta shadow	Scripted	Drives the storm surge; smashes the support stilts in Act III.	Escape quickly; follow the safe route.

08 Items and Collectibles

Item	Type	Found / use
Rowboat and oars	Equipment	Rented from Pa Lok.
Planks and canvas tarps	Puzzle items	Decks and wards. Seal windows and leaks.
Brass fuses ×3	Key items	Sealed medical tins, upper floors.
Water-damaged ledgers and medical logs	Lore / clues	Clinic offices. Reveal Sok's sanctuary and the safe combination.
Sanctified water, yellow candles	Ritual items	Carried in the satchel (source to confirm).
Terracotta Water Jar	Seal #3	Iron safe in the basement.
Burnt rubber with 1928 company stamp	Story item	Inside the jar. Points to Episode 4.

09 Audio and Visual Specification

Colour palette	Dark teal, murky brown, cold gunmetal grey, glistening wet wood, warm amber lamplight.
Post-processing	Rain on the view, water reflections, lightning flashes, lens distortion, film grain.
Light sources	Hurricane lamp, fixed wall lamps, lightning, generator indicator lights.
Ambience	Heavy rain on tin roofs, thunder, water lapping against stilts, creaking timber.
Horror sound cues	Sloshing water, wet dragging footsteps, muffled crying under the water, the chug of the diesel engine, snapping stilts.
Interface	100% diegetic. Wetness shown as a wet vignette at the screen edges; oil gauge on the lamp; maps in the sketchbook.

10 Glossary

Term (v1)	Khmer	Meaning	Note
Tonle Sap	ទន្លេសាប	The great lake of Cambodia	
Sampan	សំប៉ាន	Small wooden boat	
Chhlong Tonle	—	Drowned woman's water spirit	v1 name unclear; confirm the folk term and its spelling
Pa Lok	—	Name of the fisherman	"Grandfather" is usually តា (ta); confirm the name

11 Revision Notes and Open Issues

Changes from v1.0

- Reorganised into the standard episode structure; added mechanics, puzzle, entity, item and glossary sections.
- In-story time changed from "2:00 AM – 5:30 AM" to **1:30 AM – 5:00 AM** to match the narrative (arrival 1:30 AM, dawn 5:00 AM).
- "Fixed kerosene spotlights" renamed "fixed wall lamps"; spotlights are unusual for 1932 (large pressure or carbide lamps fit the period).
- Khmer text now renders correctly.

Open issues

DECIDE BEFORE BUILDING EPISODE 3

- **Clinic timeline:** abandoned since a 1920 accident, yet the spirit drowned "decades ago" and Sok was photographed there in 1925. Suggestion: she drowned in 1920 (twelve years earlier), and Sok used the empty clinic as a hiding place afterwards.
- **Source of the sanctified water and yellow candles** for the purification ritual.
- **Rowboat scope:** full water physics is expensive for a solo project; a guided boat on a path with limited steering is the fallback.
- **Sensitivity:** the spirit died in childbirth. Treat her story with care and review it with the cultural advisor.